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UPFRONT

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AT THE READY Indian soldiers carrying out drills at Kibithu, near the LAC, in Arunachal Pradesh

CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

INDIA-CHINA BORDER

THE TAWANG TANGLE

By Pradip R. Sagar

After over two years of an uneasy and tenuous calm on the Line of Actual Control—India's de facto border with China—a fracas between soldiers of two nuclear-armed neighbours has led to tensions flaring up again. The setting this time is not Ladakh, but Arunachal Pradesh, on the eastern sector of the LAC. In the early hours of December 9, a "larger than normal" patrol party of the People's Liberation Army (PLA) of China tried to scale a ridgeline in Yangtse, in the Tawang sector of Arunachal. The area is located around 25 km northeast of Tawang.

The build-up to the clash at Yangtse started around the last week of November 2022 when the frequency of face-offs in the sector spiked suddenly. Battalion commanders, alarmed by the sudden increase in sightings of PLA patrols in their areas of responsibility (AOR), quietly reinforced their flanks. On December 9, alert troops equipped with hand-held thermal imagers at posts overlooking known PLA ingress positions reported a large body of PLA troops forming up under the cover of the fog. According to sources on the ground, as the battalion-size force attempted to surround the position, Indian soldiers formed a human chain to deter the body of around 500 PLA soldiers. Soon, bouts of cursing and pushing ensued. Taking advantage of the chaos, PLA troops at the rear, armed with tasers, spiked clubs and other melee weapons, moved towards the front. All of this was